John Bell."

Bell "was always smiling… and he had a weakness for nonconforming people," Bertlmann said. "We had discussions, not only about physics, but also about politics, about art, and so on." Yet until Bertlmann saw Bell's paper, they had not discussed Bell's work in foundations. "When I saw [that paper], it kicked me out of my socks," he recalled. "Totally knocked me down, you can imagine. I was so excited, my heart trembled, and then I remember I went to the telephone and phoned with him. I was excited, he was very calm." Once Bertlmann had recovered, he resolved to learn more about quantum foundations. "I was shocked, and then I had to dig into this field."

Young physicists like Gisin and Bertlmann weren't the only ones attracted to quantum foundations. Older, established physicists were turning their attention to the field too—even physicists who had previously dismissed the field as irrelevant or impractical. Back when John Clauser was working on his first experimental test of Bell's inequality, in the very early 1970s, he went down to see his family in Pasadena one Christmas. Clauser's father, Francis, was a professor at Caltech at the time. "I got there, and [my dad] said 'Oh, I set up an appointment for you with Feynman!'" Clauser recalled. "I said, 'Oh, Jesus.…'" Richard Feynman was a legend, among the most prominent and brilliant physicists alive. He had been one of the architects of quantum electrodynamics, the theory of how light and matter interact—an achievement that had garnered him a Nobel Prize in 1965. Feynman had started his career as a student of John Wheeler, and, like his mentor, he had few qualms about the Copenhagen interpretation. Clauser was worried that his work on Bell's little-known theorem would be dismissed out of hand—and he wasn't wrong. "I walk into Feynman's office, and he was instantly hostile," Clauser said. "He said 'What are you doing? You don't trust quantum mechanics? Once you show something's wrong with it, come back and we'll talk about it. Get out of here, I'm not interested.'"

But by the time Alain Aspect came to speak at Caltech in 1984,